

Teaching Manual: Fractions on Number Lines

Scripted lesson | 60-75 minutes

LESSON OVERVIEW

Learning goal: Locate fractions on a number line and interpret them as distances from zero.

Success Criteria

- The student represents the idea with a model, drawing, table, or number line.
- The student uses the lesson vocabulary accurately.
- The student explains why a strategy works and checks reasonableness.
- The student can respond independently to: Draw a number line proving that $\frac{3}{4}$ is greater than $\frac{2}{4}$.

Teaching Theory

A fraction is a number built from equal parts of the same whole. The denominator names the size of the parts and the numerator counts them. Models and number lines establish magnitude before procedures.

Instructional principle: Move concrete -> pictorial -> abstract. Do not remove the model until the student can explain the symbolic work.

Lesson Flow

5-8 min	Number talk
10 min	Vocabulary and worked example
20 min	Main lesson
15 min	Practice
10 min	Challenge
5 min	Exit check

Materials: Preparation and Use

BEFORE THE STUDENT ARRIVES

String or tape number line	Prepare before the lesson and introduce it only when it supports the current mathematical idea.
fraction cards	Cut and shuffle beforehand. Reveal only the cards needed for the current example.
rulers.	Check the tool and units before the lesson. Demonstrate one accurate reading, then let the student handle it.

Table Setup

- Center: the main model or tool for today's lesson.
- Student side: packet, pencil, and only the materials currently needed.
- Teacher side: answer notes and observation record, kept out of student view.
- Leave a clear space where the student can point, move pieces, and explain.

Vocabulary to Establish

fraction: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

numerator: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

denominator: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

unit fraction: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

equivalent: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

benchmark: Ask the student for an example or picture before refining the definition.

Material rule: The student should touch, draw, measure, or organize the mathematics before copying a procedure.

Phase 1: Launch and Number Talk

EXACT TEACHER LANGUAGE

Teacher says	"Today we are learning to locate fractions on a number line and interpret them as distances from zero. Before I show a method, I want to hear how you see the numbers."
Why	Positions the student as a mathematical thinker and makes prior knowledge visible.
Listen for	Useful representations, precise vocabulary, and whether the student checks reasonableness.
Then do	Acknowledge the idea neutrally, then ask for evidence rather than immediately evaluating it.

Number Talk Prompt

Teacher says	"Where would $\frac{1}{2}$ be between 0 and 1?"
Why	Surfaces the relationships needed in the main lesson.
Listen for	Any reasoning connected to fractions, not only a final answer.
Then do	Ask: 'Can you show that another way?' Record two distinct strategies when possible.

Prompt Ladder

First: What do you notice? What could you try?
Next: Can you draw, build, or organize the information?
Then: Which part of today's vocabulary fits your idea?
Last resort: Solve a smaller related case, then return to the original.

Phase 2: Explicit Teaching

MODEL, QUESTION, CONNECT

Teaching Step 1

Teacher says	"Let us mark 0 and 1. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 2

Teacher says	"Let us partition the interval into equal fourths. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 3

Teacher says	"Let us label $\frac{1}{4}$, $\frac{2}{4}$, $\frac{3}{4}$, and $\frac{4}{4}$. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 4

Teacher says	"Let us emphasize that points, not spaces, represent numbers. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Teaching Step 5

Teacher says	"Let us repeat with thirds and sixths. Tell me what I should do first and why."
Why	Keeps the student cognitively active during explicit instruction.
Listen for	A connection between the representation and the mathematical symbols.
Then do	Model only the next move. Pause and return responsibility to the student.

Representation check: Before leaving the model, ask the student to point to every part of the matching equation or statement.

Phase 3: Guided and Independent Practice

RELEASE RESPONSIBILITY GRADUALLY

I Do -> We Do -> You Do

- I do: complete the packet's worked example while narrating the reason for each move.
- We do: solve the first practice task together; the student chooses the representation.
- You do: the student completes the remaining tasks while explaining selected answers.

Teacher says	"Practice task 1: Place fractions on number lines. Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Teacher says	"Practice task 2: Identify missing labels. Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Teacher says	"Practice task 3: Match shape models to number-line locations. Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Teacher says	"Practice task 4: Explain why $\frac{4}{4} = 1$. Before solving, tell me what the task is asking and which tool might help."
Listen for	Correct interpretation before computation.
Then do	Use the prompt ladder. Avoid completing a step the student can perform.

Common Misconceptions

Watch for: Comparing denominators as if larger always means greater.

Watch for: Using unequal wholes when comparing fractions.

Watch for: Treating numerator and denominator as unrelated whole numbers.

Differentiation

Secure: Remove routine repetition and ask for a second method, proof, or generalization.

Developing: Keep the visual model visible and reduce the number size while preserving the same structure.

Fragile: Return to a concrete example, use one question at a time, and delay independent symbols.

Phase 4: Challenge, Assessment, and Feedback

PROTECT PRODUCTIVE STRUGGLE

Teacher says	"Challenge: Place $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{2}{3}$, and $\frac{3}{4}$ on the same number line accurately. You may draw, make a table, test a simpler case, or work backward. I will give you thinking time before offering a hint."
Why	Builds persistence and strategy selection rather than rapid answer production.
Listen for	An organized plan, revision after a failed attempt, and a justification.
Then do	Praise a specific mathematical action: organization, checking, representation, or explanation.

Exit Check

Teacher says	"Complete this independently: Draw a number line proving that $\frac{3}{4}$ is greater than $\frac{2}{4}$."
Why	Provides evidence of the central lesson goal without teacher prompting.
Then do	After completion, ask one clarifying question only if the written reasoning is ambiguous.

Evidence Guide

Secure	Correct and independently justified	Proceed; add a variation or ask the student to teach the idea.
Developing	Correct with model or prompt	Proceed with the model available and begin next lesson with retrieval.
Fragile	Incorrect structure or unexplained answer	Reteach with smaller quantities and a concrete representation.

Answer and Observation Guide

USE AFTER INDEPENDENT WORK

Expected Mathematical Evidence

- Number talk: a defensible response to 'Where would $\frac{1}{2}$ be between 0 and 1?' with a model or explanation.
- Main lesson: evidence that the student can locate fractions on a number line and interpret them as distances from zero.
- Practice: accurate work with units, labels, and a reasonableness check where appropriate.
- Challenge: an organized attempt at 'Place $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{2}{3}$, and $\frac{3}{4}$ on the same number line accurately.' and an explanation of the chosen strategy.
- Exit: an independent response to 'Draw a number line proving that $\frac{3}{4}$ is greater than $\frac{2}{4}$.'

Teacher Verification Routine

- Rework every numerical answer before marking it.
- Accept a different method when the reasoning is valid.
- For open problems, verify that every condition is satisfied.
- For measurement, data, and geometry, require correct units and labels.
- For explanations, distinguish a correct statement from a demonstrated reason.

Observation Record

A strong strategy the student used:

A misconception to revisit:

Vocabulary used precisely:

Material or representation that helped:

Plan for the next lesson:
